

The Flavors of North America

Ask most people around the globe to name the quintessential food of North America and the answer will most probably be “the hamburger.” It is true that a good hamburger is available in almost every small town or big city across the US. But North American cuisine – including its fast food – is far more complex and varied, encompassing everything from homemade pies and perfect barbecue to succulent seafood, southern “soul food,” and fiery Mexican dishes.

As Europeans discovered when they began colonizing the New World 500 years ago, the American continent is almost embarrassingly rich in natural food sources and fertile land. The icy waters of the northeast coast yield some of the world’s finest shellfish, while much of the world’s wheat springs from the black soil of North America’s plains. Fruit trees groan with the weight of peaches in Georgia, apples in the Okanagan Valley, and oranges, lemons, and limes in Florida and California. Tomatoes

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and peppers grow as far as the eye can see in Mexico, and rippling corn stretches to the horizon through the American Midwest.

Nowhere is the taste of North America so celebrated as in northern California, where almost anything will grow. It was here that the farm-to-fork movement took root in the late 1960s, and so-called “California cuisine” – the concept of eating only fresh and local foods – has evolved into the driving force behind fine dining across virtually the whole of North America.

Yet North American cuisine has a distinctly casual streak. The slapdash grill menu – hamburgers included – met the American love affair with automobiles, especially in southern California, to

give birth to the roadside diner. Even the streamlined architecture of this icon of American gastronomy reflects the worship of speed. While Americans hardly invented handheld food, few cities boast such a variety of street food as New York, where the diner on the move can chow down on German wurst in Midtown or Sri Lankan *dosas* in Washington Square Park.

Indigenous Ingredients

Transplanted ethnic cuisines are emblematic of North American gastronomy, yet certain dishes are rooted in their geography. Thanks to air freight, Maine lobster can be tasted all over the world, but never with such resonance as on the dock where it is landed. Clam chowder may trace its ancestry to Breton fish stews, but the clams that define it are limited to New England shores. And few dishes are so location-specific as New Orleans jambalaya, which

Right Cooking up a huge pot of chili at the Kansas State Fair Chili Cookoff
Below New York City’s love of street food is indulged at its many street fairs

